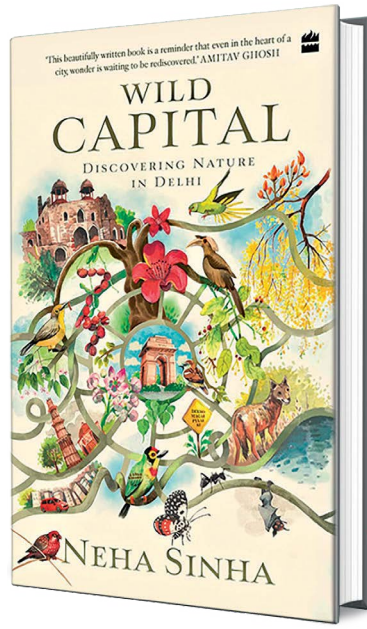
THE COLONIAL RUPTURE IN THE 19TH CENTURY CONVERTED FORESTS FROM A COMMONS TO A MANAGED RESOURCE

live trapping of elephants. Sovereignty has always been performed in the forest. Maya Ratnam's essay on the Baiga community examines people whose lives are inseparable from it, while the semi-nomadic Van Gujjars offer a parallel study in pastoralism as an ecological force. Mukul Sharma examines the politics of sacred groves and the Sarna—the indigenous faith of Jharkhand's Adivasi communities—where the sacred and the political coexist uneasily. Sacred groves exist across India, from the *devrai* of Maharashtra to the *kavu* of Kerala, yet the essay overlooks them.

The arguments are scholarly and on occasion pedantic, but the book's silences are telling. The Andaman biomes, the forests of Great Nicobar, the community forests of Arunachal Pradesh—whole forest worlds are unaccounted for. Their exclusion is a glaring limitation, particularly as the Forest (Conservation) Amendment Act of 2023 redraws the boundaries of what legally counts as forest in India. Perhaps that answers the question of what forests are for—albeit disturbingly. ■

—Bijoy Venugopal



WILD CAPITAL: Discovering Nature in Delhi
By Neha Sinha
HARPERCOLLINS
₹799; 320 pages

BOOKS ▼

URBAN JUNGLE

Conservation biologist Neha Sinha's *Wild Capital* is a passionate love letter to Delhi's natural environs

Endearingly personal and enchantingly wild, *Wild Capital* explores Delhi and its immediate outskirts for—well, for a lot else, but mostly—"unfettered, uncalculating, animal joy". It is full of science and stories, curiosity and poetry, knowledge and love. *Oropetium* grasses and *ornithophilous* flowers sit comfortably with mahua blossoms that taste of "sunshine and honey made solid". Or with the native Aravalli trees that remain small for years "seemingly bent in a complicated conversation with themselves".

A conservation biologist, Neha Sinha is not just pursuing the lesser known but also helping us look with fresh and curious eyes at the quotidian. With her, and with the experts she accompanies, we explore city forests being domesticated into parks, the central Ridge, the Mangar Bani forest, biodiversity sites, the Yamuna and even the green spaces around heritage monuments. The book has tales of memory and loss but also of possibilities and trembling hope.

THE BOOK HAS TALES OF MEMORY AND LOSS BUT ALSO OF POSSIBILITIES AND TREMBLING HOPE. IT IS RICH WITH EXQUISITE ATTENTION TOWARDS TINY THINGS

It is rich with exquisite attention being paid to tiny, not-yet-thought-of things: biological soil crust over rocks; strands of spider's web that hold together a paradise flycatcher's nest; grey hornbills' eyelashes. There are owls and civets in Sanjay Van, fireflies in Hauz Khas, kites on semal trees, a plenitude of heart-shaped leaves in the Ridge, the scent of clean, uncorrupted soil in Mangar Bani. And the lyrical names of Aravalli Biodiversity Park's native trees, unfamiliar to most of us: kullu, salai, kair, dhau, kareel....

This book is also a rewriting of animal and plant grammar into our thoughts, making parakeet a verb ("parakeeting through life" is facing life with a defiant squawk!) and rewilding metaphors ("as resilient as a kumat thorn", "unbeatable as a dhau"). If you start opening yourself to nature, it's okay to not have the authority of knowledge, it's okay to think of a tree as perhaps-palash. "The name of this tree is my tree."

Wild Capital is a diary, nature guide, manifesto and passionate love letter. My best review is that it made me start visiting the spaces it described that were new to me, armed with binoculars, inquisitiveness, wonder and hope. ■

—Juhi Saklani